

As Air Chief, one of Mukerjee's most vital tasks was modernizing the IAF's aircraft and equipment. One of the new planes acquired during his term was the Dassault Mystère IVA, the first transonic (very near the speed of sound) aircraft used in India.

Mukerjee served under three British chiefs, gaining valuable administrative experience that enabled him to take over in 1954 as the IAF's first Indian chief and shape the future of the Indian Air Force.

In full flight

As one of the IAF's earliest members, Mukerjee played a foundational role in how the IAF was administered and operated, as well as in how its members related to each other (for instance, he is believed to have helped introduce inter-community dining, where servicemen of all castes and religions ate together). In the late 1930s, Mukerjee and the IAF undertook their first real operation in the North-West Frontier Province, aiding the army's operations against the local tribal population. Here, Mukerjee earned himself a reputation for steadiness, quick thinking and compassion. Over the next few years, he grew to be the IAF's most senior officer, the first Indian to command a squadron and a station, and to be appointed Deputy Chief of Air Staff in 1947.